

COLLECTION · BUYERS

The Real Costs of Buying

*Notary, inspection, adjustments and more — the
full budget, no surprises*

READ BEFORE YOU BEGIN

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The Real Costs of Buying

Notary, inspection, adjustments and more — the full budget, no surprises

The listed price is only the beginning. Between the down payment and the keys, a series of very real costs add up — and forgetting them is one of the main sources of stress in a first purchase.

This guide gives a full tour of the closing costs and start-up expenses, with orders of magnitude to budget well.

Each chapter ends with a lined “My notes” page to build YOUR complete buying budget.

The listed price is never the real cost of a purchase. This guide lists all the fees — around the transaction, the Welcome Tax, start-up, then the recurring costs — to build a complete budget with no nasty surprises.

The amounts (2026 edition) are orders of magnitude: have your specific case quantified by your notary and your broker.

CHAPTER

The fees paid around the transaction

Listing the costs directly tied to the purchase.

- Notary fees (deed of sale, mortgage deed, verifications).
- Pre-purchase inspection and, if needed, specialized expert assessments (roof, pyrite, etc.).
- An up-to-date location certificate, if a new one is required (land surveyor).
- Property appraisal if the lender requires it.
- Adjustments: municipal/school taxes already paid by the seller, remaining heating oil, condo fees.

These amounts are generally settled at signing (except the Welcome Tax, billed later).

These fees all fall around the same time, around the transaction: plan for them in cash, on top of the down payment. A written estimate from your notary and your broker, from the start, spares you the stressful “how much do I need to bring” question the day before signing.

EMILIE'S TIP

Ask your notary for an estimated “statement of disbursements” before signing.

Seeing all the fees at once avoids the nasty surprise on the big day.

CHAPTER

The Welcome Tax, separately

Never forgetting this item billed after the purchase.

The transfer duties (Welcome Tax) aren't paid at the notary's: the municipality sends a separate bill, a few weeks to a few months later. On an average-priced property, this often amounts to several thousand dollars (see the dedicated guide for the calculation).

The Welcome Tax deserves a line of its own because it arrives AFTER the purchase, by municipal bill: many forget it in their budget and get caught out. Set the money aside right at the transaction — it's one of the most common cash-flow surprises for new owners.

EMILIE'S TIP

Set the estimated Welcome Tax amount aside as soon as you sign, in a separate account. It's the classic trap: the bill arrives after the move.

CHAPTER

Start-up expenses

Planning the cost of “taking possession”.

- Home insurance active from the moment you take possession.
- Hook-ups and transfers (Hydro-Québec, internet, etc.).
- The move (truck, movers, boxes).
- Locks, first purchases (curtains, missing appliances, small jobs).
- A start-up maintenance reserve (~1%/year of the value, to be set aside).

The start-up expenses (insurance, hook-ups, locks, small purchases, first jobs) add up fast in the first weeks. Plan a dedicated envelope so you don't finance your move-in on credit, at the worst moment.

EMILIE'S TIP

Keep an emergency cushion AFTER the purchase. Many new owners reach the keys with a drained account; a surprise in the first year isn't a question of “if”, but of “when”.

CHAPTER

Building your complete buying budget

Assembling all the items into a single figure.

Your total budget = down payment + closing costs (notary, inspection, adjustments, certificate) + Welcome Tax + start-up expenses + emergency cushion. It's this overall figure, and not the down payment alone, that determines whether you're really ready.

By calculating it early, you avoid the most stressful scenario: having just enough for the entry, and nothing for everything else.

Assemble it all into a single figure: down payment + closing costs + start-up + cushion. It's this total — not just the listed price or the mortgage — that determines whether you buy comfortably or tight. A complete, written budget protects you from nasty surprises.

EMILIE'S TIP

Make your complete buying budget BEFORE shopping seriously. It's what tells you the price range you're truly comfortable in — not just your pre-approval.

CHAPTER

After the purchase: the recurring costs

Planning the property's real cost.

The buying fees are one-time; owning a property also means **recurring costs** to factor into your monthly budget:

- **Taxes** (municipal and school).
- **Home insurance**.
- **Energy** (heating, electricity).
- **Maintenance** (routine) and condo fees, where applicable.

A purchase that's “affordable” at the entry can become heavy if these recurring costs are underestimated.

Owning also means recurring costs: municipal and school taxes, insurance, energy, maintenance, condo fees where applicable. A purchase that's “affordable” at the entry can become heavy if these monthly costs are underestimated: calculate them before committing.

EMILIE'S TIP

Add up all the real monthly costs, not just the mortgage, before committing. It's that total that will determine whether you live comfortably or tight in your new property.

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

Your next steps, concretely.

This week

1. List all the fee items for my price range.
2. Ask for an estimate of the notary's fees.

Within 30 days

1. Estimate the Welcome Tax and mentally set it aside.
2. Assemble my total buying budget, cushion included.

Next

1. Validate this budget with Emilie and my mortgage broker.

For a surprise-free budget

1. Get a written estimate of all my closing costs before making an offer.
2. Set aside the Welcome Tax and a cushion right at the transaction.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- Closing costs: notary, inspection, adjustments, location certificate.
 - Adjustments: reimbursing the seller for prepaid amounts.
 - Statement of disbursements: the notary's estimate of the fees at signing.
 - Welcome Tax: billed separately after the purchase.
 - Emergency cushion: a reserve for surprises after the purchase.
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- Closing costs: notary, Welcome Tax, adjustments, inspection, insurance.
 - Adjustments: taxes and fees prepaid by the seller, reimbursed pro rata.
 - Recurring costs: taxes, insurance, energy, maintenance, condo fees.
 - Emergency cushion: a reserve for surprises in the first months.
 - Taking possession: the moment when insurance and hook-ups must be active.

GOING FURTHER

Quiz — test your knowledge

1. The notary's fees cover:

- A) The move
- B) The deed of sale, the mortgage deed and the verifications
- C) The Welcome Tax
- D) Car insurance

2. The adjustments at the notary's notably concern:

- A) The colour of the walls
- B) Taxes already paid by the seller, heating oil, condo fees
- C) The rent
- D) The salary

3. The Welcome Tax is paid:

- A) At the notary's
- B) By municipal bill, after the purchase
- C) Every month
- D) Never

4. Home insurance must be active:

- A) A year later
- B) From the moment you take possession
- C) Never
- D) Only in winter

5. The start-up maintenance reserve is about:

- A) 0%
- B) 1%/year of the value
- C) 25%
- D) 50%

6. The total buying budget includes:

- A) The down payment alone
- B) Down payment + closing costs + Welcome Tax + start-up + cushion
- C) The mortgage alone
- D) Nothing more than the price

7. The classic trap is:

- A) Too much savings
- B) Having just enough for the entry and nothing for the rest
- C) Paying cash
- D) Too much insurance

8. An estimated statement of disbursements comes from:

- A) The municipality
- B) The notary
- C) The inspector
- D) The neighbour

Answer key

- 1. **B** — The notary prepares the deeds and checks the titles (ch. 1).
- 2. **B** — You reimburse the seller for what they prepaid (ch. 1).
- 3. **B** — A separate bill, after the transaction (ch. 2).
- 4. **B** — Mandatory from possession (ch. 3).
- 5. **B** — About 1%/year to set aside (ch. 3).
- 6. **B** — It's the overall figure that counts (ch. 4).
- 7. **B** — You forget the fees beyond the down payment (ch. 4).
- 8. **B** — The notary can estimate it before signing (ch. 1).

Signé PAR Em

*Thank you for reading. May this guide help you
decide with confidence, with all the information
in hand.*

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